

Just Not Getting the Picture on Tobacco



BANDEEP SINGH

Rules to implement pictorial warnings on cigarette packs were notified first in 2006 and were to come into force in February 2007. But in August, Parliament amended the law to make the skull and bones sign optional. In September, a fresh set of milder warnings was notified. India had to comply with the pictorial warnings by February 28, 2008 but in August, the deadline was fixed for November and put off to March 2009. Will it now be implemented by May 30?

Laws go ultra mild ...

Additional health warning:
Not more than 20% on one side, globally 30% at least

Stringency:
Picture less effective, skull and bones sign optional

Words:
Misleading words like "mild" or "light" banned initially, but optional now



Maximum per cigarette:
Globally, it is 10 mg of tar and 1 mg of nicotine while in India, tar is between 16-24 mg and nicotine 1.5-2 mg

General health warning:
Originally 50% of the packaging; now reduced to 40%

* Source: *Communicating Risk to Smokers*, Am J Prev Med. 2007 March; Healix Sekhsaria Institute for Public Health; HRIDAY

WHO'S DOING WHAT



CANADA

Most Stringent
16 picture/text warnings, 50% front and 20% back, since 2000



UK

Very Stringent
16 text warnings, 30% front and 40% back, since 2004



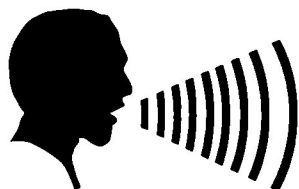
AUSTRALIA

Fairly Stringent
6 text warnings, 25% front and 33% back, since 1995



USA

Least Stringent
4 text warnings on the side of the packs only, unchanged since 1984



Voicing Concern

A group of people who meet every Saturday at 2 p.m. in Connaught Place, Delhi, and are often seen sitting for hours, may be mistaken as lobbyists, but they are members of a new movement unfolding across India—The Indian Stammerers Association. If 1 per cent of every country's population stammers, then there are one crore stammerers in India. And they have decided to help themselves cope with the speech issues that they face. Not just in Delhi, they are also meeting up in other cities. So if you need help, don't hesitate.

Fun Way to Wellness

When Mumbai physician Dr Madan Kataria burst into loud and hearty laughter with five others in a park in 1995, he started a revolution to spread mirth with his laughter therapy. Today his Laughter Yoga is a global phenomenon and here's why: 10 minutes of belly laughter equals to 30 minutes on a rowing machine or running for half-an-hour on a jogging track. It increases the oxygen flow in your body, keeps your blood pressure under control, gives you a stronger immune system and reduces stress. Many reasons for you to laugh along.

HEMANT CHAWLA



BIRTH RIGHT

The maternity healthcare sector has some good news for would-be moms: birthing chairs. Popular in the West, they help women deliver easily and in less time. Since most of the deliveries in India are done in a lying posture, if adopted, these chairs are likely to reverse the trend of women opting for caesarean procedures. The only dampener is the cost of the chair—about \$20,000 (Rs 10 lakh)—which is likely to push up the cost of delivery.

■ Compiled by Damayanti Datta